NPI Licensing Beyond Downward Entailment

Conference abstract

Author One Author Two

Abstract

This abstract argues that negative polarity item (NPI) licensing cannot be reduced to downward entailment alone. Using Czech data with *většina* 'most', we show that NPIs can be acceptable in a genuinely non-monotonic environment, which is difficult to reconcile with classical Ladusaw-style accounts. The result supports a scope-based analysis on which NPIs mark narrow scope relative to their licensor rather than a specific monotonicity profile.

Abstract

Negative polarity items have traditionally been analyzed as requiring downward-entailing licensing environments. The present study re-examines that assumption with Czech data centered on the proportional quantifier *většina* 'most'. Since *most* is genuinely non-monotonic, it provides a sharper test than standard downward-entailing versus upward-entailing contrasts.

We combined an acceptability task with an inference task. Speakers found NPIs more acceptable with *all* than with *some*, but importantly, *most* patterned in between rather than collapsing with *some*. In the inference task, *most* did not show a stable monotonicity profile, yet it still licensed the NPI in a way that was distinct from both classical downward-entailing and upward-entailing environments. This dissociation suggests that licensing is not exhausted by logical monotonicity.

The analysis is naturally captured by a scope-marking approach. In this view, the NPI signals narrow scope relative to its licensor, which allows licensing in environments that are not downward-entailing. A conference version of the paper can present the Czech examples in the standard linguex format.

The main contribution is empirical: the data identify a genuinely non-monotonic licensor that still interacts with NPIs. The theoretical payoff is that the licensing condition looks closer to scope than to downward entailment. More broadly, the findings support a grammar in which polarity sensitivity is domain-sensitive and mediated by structural scope relations rather than a single monotonicity check.

References

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